# Apple Fitness+ Usability Testing Research Report

**SI 303: Introduction to Qualitative Research Methods**

**University of Michigan School of Information**

**Client**

Apple Fitness+ *(class project, no affiliation)*

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## Introduction

As part of coursework for SI 303 - Introduction to Qualitative Research Methods at the University of Michigan School of Information, our research team conducted usability tests of the Apple Fitness+ app. Apple Fitness+ is a subscription-based fitness platform that offers a variety of guided workout content. The platform also supports customized fitness plans, wellness content (e.g. meditations, yoga, and mindfulness), and independent exercise tracking. The objective of these tests was to identify any challenges users of Apple Fitness+ face when searching for and discovering workout classes and plans, saving them for later, and customizing their playback experience in the Apple Fitness+ app. These are core features of Apple Fitness+ that must be seamlessly integrated into the experience for the app to be as enticing an option as possible for users of guided workout platforms. Given how saturated the market for guided workout content is, especially free content, it is essential that Apple Fitness+ helps create the ideal workout experience that differentiates it from its competitors and justifies the subscription cost.

Our target participants for this research were those who exercise at least once per week and who have never used Apple Fitness+ before. We aimed to find participants who use guided workout materials somewhat regularly and have an Apple device as well, since our usability testing focused on a realistic task flow that a user of Apple Fitness+ might complete. These users are some of the most likely and relevant users that Apple Fitness+ might have.

Participants were asked to complete tasks involving workout searching and filtering, saving workouts for later, managing queues and plans, setting goals, and adjusting in-workout settings. These tasks were selected because they all represent key points within the app where users will feel either confident in continuing with Apple Fitness+ or become frustrated enough to abandon the platform. Through our usability testing, we aimed to evaluate how easily users could navigate Apple Fitness+, understand the available features, and complete common workout-related actions. This allows us to provide recommendations for Apple to make Apple Fitness+ features clearer, more navigable, and assistive with their users' fitness routines. This study aims to identify ways Apple Fitness+ can reduce friction, increase user confidence, and strengthen its value as a paid guided workout platform.

Using our test data, we have identified four key areas where significant usability gaps exist and recommended improvements for each area, including:

1. Updating the "Workout" page and icon to better represent its functionality and eliminate confusion when searching for guided workout videos.

2. Removing the term “Stack” and replacing it with a more intuitive term to minimize errors caused by the uncommon name of this feature.
3. Improving the visibility of the search, filter, and sort features to reduce search times and align Apple Fitness+ with other Apple interfaces
4. Redesign the “Summary” page around personalized goals and content to give more visibility to fitness goals, helping to support users’ motivations

## Methods

For this study, a total of 12 participants were recruited for usability testing. To recruit participants, we talked to friends, colleagues, and family members who were ideally college students (undergraduate or graduate-level) or working professionals (ages 22-35). We focused on participants who exercise at least once per week and who have never used Apple Fitness+ before. We aimed to find participants who use guided workout materials somewhat regularly (at least once per month), or had used guided materials at least as frequently in the past. Ideally, we looked for participants who owned an iPhone/iPad/any Apple device that can access Apple Fitness+, although that isn’t required for this research. Some time and sampling constraints meant that not all participants fit the ideal criteria, but we did the best we could to find participants with the above characteristics. However, we did exclude any participants who had used Apple Fitness+ in the last 6 months, as they might skew the results of this testing, as previous users of the app.

Before the beginning of testing, we performed pilot testing in our quantitative research class discussion sections and among ourselves, and received feedback from course instructors on our tasks. We recorded tasks to better match the natural flow of us on the app, and reduced the number of tasks related to searching and adding classes to the user’s library. We also made later tasks build on previous tasks by adding context clues in the wording of the tasks, and made sure that every task used as clear terminology as possible, which didn’t lead the user towards a specific feature or place on the app.

For testing, we conducted all of our tests in person in a place comfortable for the user, most in their own homes. We chose this setting to make the user as comfortable as possible and to help get the best testing results. Before testing, we prepared by reviewing relevant materials around best practices for usability testing moderation, such as articles and video resources from Nielsen Norman Group.[1]

[1] NNG Article: https://www.nngroup.com/articles/talking-to-users/
NNG Video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bcfqmx2hnUQ

| Participant ID | Age | Relevant Characteristics | Interview Method | Interviewer |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| P1 | 20 | - UX sophomore (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Active and has utilized YouTube guided video workout materials in the past | In person (participant's home) | Nick Pisarczyk |
| P2 | 28 | - Law grad student (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Active and heavily utilized Peloton guided workout materials in the past year | In person (participant's home) | Nick Pisarczyk |
| P3 | 28 | - Young professional (late 20s)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Active and heavily utilized Peloton guided workout materials in the past year | In person (participant's home) | Nick Pisarczyk |
| P4 | 19 | - Econ sophomore student (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness | In person | Bisher Habbab |
| P5 | 19 | - Econ sophomore student (UM)<br>- Not familiar with Apple Fitness | In person | Bisher Habbab |
| P6 | 25 | - 3rd yr Med Student (Not UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- No Experience w/ guided workout platforms/formats | In person | Bisher Habbab |
| P7 | 50 | - Older professional (50)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Consistently active(15+yrs)<br>- Experience w/ multiple guided workout platforms/formats | In person (participant's home) | Andrew Stetz |
| P8 | 23 | - Sports business grad student (not UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Active, has used multiple forms of guided workouts | In person (participant's home) | Andrew Stetz |
| P9 | 21 | - Biochem student (not UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Active, has used multiple forms of guided workouts | In person (participant's home) | Andrew Stetz |
| P10 | 22 | - Physics student (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Consistently active (rowing team)<br>- Experience w/ multiple guided workout platforms/formats | In person (participant's home) | Liam Kendall |
| P11 | 22 | - Environment student (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness<br>- Workout activity varies<br>- Uses a different app to help track and guide weight lifting | In person (participant's home) | Liam Kendall |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| P12 | 19 | - Communications & Media student (UM)<br>- Has not used Apple Fitness but lifts regularly<br>- Used to use guided workouts occasionally, but not currently | In person (participant's home) | Liam Kendall |

*Figure 1: Participant Information*

To record the tests, we used Zoom with screen sharing enabled on the test device to capture the inputs of the users on Apple Fitness+. To set up the Apple Fitness+ app for testing, we ensured that we performed the test on a device with full access to an Apple Fitness+ paid subscription and an internet connection (many key features of the app we wanted to test are locked behind the subscription paywall). Before beginning the tests, we ensured that the search history was cleared on the search page, the library was cleared of all saved workouts, queues, etc., and that calorie goals were set to 650 calories for each day. We also made sure to reset the "Metrics" clock overlay that shows while in a workout, but we ran into issues with the clock overlay showing automatically anyway, even after turning it off. We encountered other bugs on the app as well – for example, one of us had a download in our library we couldn't get rid of.

To analyze the testing data, we used an almost text-based form of affinity diagramming. Each team member independently reviewed their own three participants' data logs after completing the logs. We used the recordings of the testing to fill out most of what's found on the logs, as well as to review to understand the key issues each of our individual participants faced during the testing. We wrote out the key issues we saw during testing for each participant, then combined those three participants' issues into larger codes. In a shared brainstorming document, we logged both the data points and codes, and compared the codes and data we found among our own participants to those the other team members found with their participants. We synthesized these codes for each subset of participants into four overarching "themes" that ended up becoming our four key findings and recommendations, detailed below. We prioritized the themes that showed up the most frequently among multiple participants, and those that seemed to have the most impact on participants throughout testing. We used statistics from our logging to back up our initial intuition as well, ensuring we had adequate numbers of participants and relevant data to go along with each finding and recommendation.

# Findings and Recommendations

## Key Finding & Recommendation #1

### Confusion Over the “Workout” Page’s Functionality

The Apple Fitness+ app includes a “Workout” page that allows users to log workout activities such as running, walking, or cycling. Compared to the rest of the content on Apple Fitness+, this logging feature is fairly insignificant. However, based on the app’s design, the “Workout” page’s location in the bottom navigation bar places it on the same level of importance as the entire Apple Fitness+ experience, which creates a significant area for error when users are looking to watch a workout video.

During our usability testing, Participant 8 checked the “Workout” page during 3 different tasks, assuming they would be able to complete the task this way. Participant 2 spent 40 seconds during Task 2 attempting to create a custom workout plan on the “Workout” page. This led to frustration with the task and the app itself, as P2 expressed, “To be honest, I thought this app was gonna be better than it is.” Participant 3 also became stuck on this page for 60 seconds during Task 3. These errors represent a large gulf of execution between the goal of searching for a workout and the function of the “Workout” page. This gulf exists due to the poor naming of the page compared to its functionality, as well as its placement in the bottom navigation suggesting it is a much more significant feature of Apple Fitness than it really is. As one of the most essential features of Apple Fitness+ is viewing a workout video, this represents a significant flaw as our test data shows a clear hindrance in users’ ability to find workout videos.

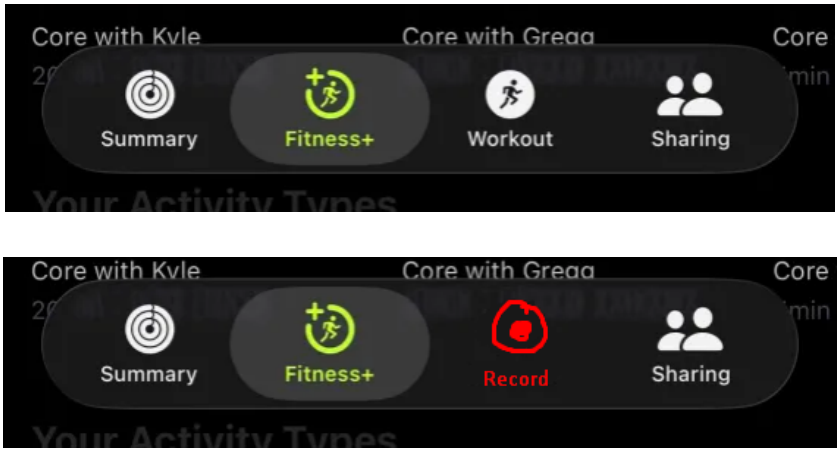



Figure 2: Original vs Recommended Navigation Bar

**Recommendation: Rename the tab to "Record" and change the icon to the Apple Screen Recording icon**

The original Fitness+ and Workout logos are essentially the same, except the Workout is filled in. Since the iconography and naming are similar, it makes sense why users were getting confused with this tab.

The fix for this issue is simple. Renaming the "Workout" tab to "Record" and changing the icon to the iOS screen recording icon communicates the idea of this page much better. Users on this page want to actively record an activity, not passively view a class while following a guide. The "Record" verbiage clearly communicates user input in a way that "Workout" does not, and the new icon is already familiar to iPhone users, making the intent of the page immediately clear once they enter the tab.

## Key Finding & Recommendation #2

### Finding: Strange “Stack” terminology causes users to second-guess themselves

Apple Fitness+ calls what many platforms call a “queue” or“playlist” a "Stack." This feature allows users to line up multiple workouts in a row–a common use case might be a stretch warm-up, a ‘main’ workout, and a short cooldown yoga class. However, this naming convention was confusing to our participants, especially during tasks 5 and 8. 8/12 participants had trouble with this, and multiple voiced frustrations during testing or afterwards during post-test questioning. For example, P7 gave up on resetting the queue because they didn’t understand where the Stack was, and P9 spent over three minutes searching through all the pages and even typing "queue" in the search bar, only to find the Stack by accident. P9 said Task 5 was the hardest, mainly because of the confusing terminology. P12 never found the Stack button and failed the task. Some participants who successfully found the feature hesitated, like P8, who asked if clearing a stack was the same as clearing a queue.

While the task had to be worded differently (using “queue” instead of “stack”) from the naming conventions used in Apple Fitness+ to mitigate leading the user, these results still show that the naming convention is strange. Users had no trouble understanding that a “class” meant a guided workout video, for example, so there seems to be an issue with the “Stack” naming. This is a big deal because a queue on a workout app is important; it’s how users line up multiple workouts, which is a core usability pattern on a fitness app like Apple Fitness+. P1 mentioned how a similar feature is present on Peloton, but that the queue Competitors like Peloton use simpler words like "queue" or "playlist" and avoid this kind of mix-up. Because of this naming problem, two participants couldn’t finish Task 5, and several others wasted a lot of time searching. Small issues like this can push first-time users away, especially for a paid app in a market saturated with free alternatives.

### Recommendation: Rename "Stack" to "Up Next" or “Queue”, and add an always-visible tooltip to the menu

Rename the Stack feature to Up Next (or Queue) across the app: the icon label, the menu header, and any in-product references. "Up Next" is consistent with the

language Apple already uses in its Music and Podcasts apps, leveraging a mental model that users, particularly those already in the Apple ecosystem, have established. This change preserves an already-existing label Apple users are familiar with, while removing the need to learn and process new terminology.

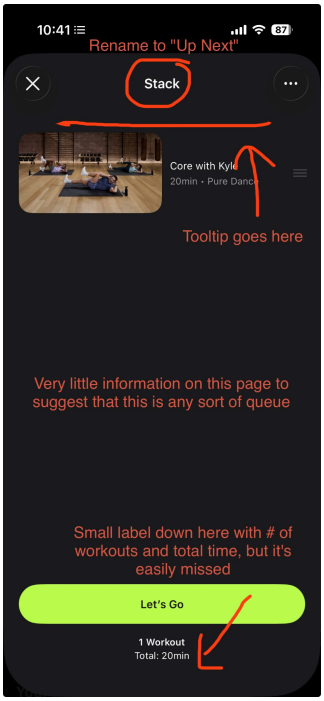



*Figure 3 - Apple Fitness+ Stack Design Change Recommendations*

Additionally, when a user opens the Stack/Up Next menu, display a tooltip at the top of the menu briefly explaining the feature: *"Add workouts here to play them back-to-back."* This addresses the secondary problem we observed, even after users found the Stack, several were unsure of what it actually did or how it differed from saving to the Library. P9 explicitly asked, *"Is this the queue? I don't feel like the Workout page is the queue, but I'm not actually sure,"* a moment of doubt that a single onboarding tooltip would resolve.

## Key Finding & Recommendation #3

### Finding: Poor visibility of navigational buttons

In our tests, multiple users showed difficulty locating key navigational and browsing features on the app. The search icon, unlike other Apple interfaces, is hidden by default and requires users to scroll right on the top navigation bar.

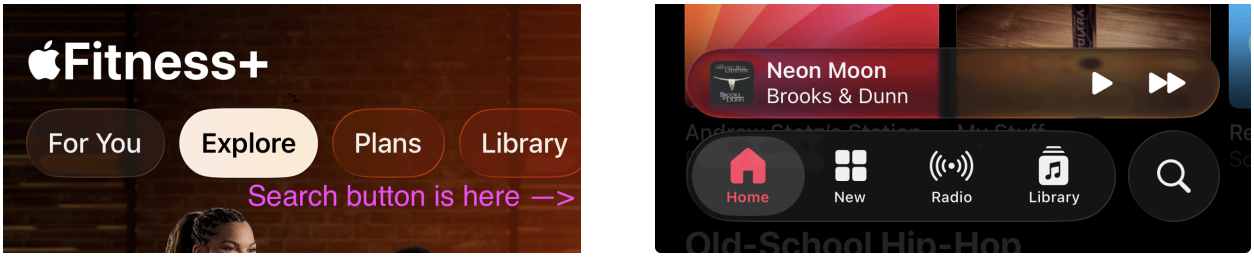



*Figure 4: Apple Fitness+ vs. Apple Music search*

Furthermore, the filter and sort features were shown to have a poor presence on the page. These buttons are not placed next to each other and are not the same style of button; the filter button has a neon green background and is placed above the description of the current page (instructor or activity type) whereas the sort button has no background and is placed below this description. This mismatch makes these features very easy to overlook for unfamiliar users. More specifically, Participants 7 and 8 spent 34 and 20 seconds, respectively, scrolling through the entire list of workouts when completing Task 4, after they both overlooked the sorting and filtering options at the top of the page. Additionally, P8 noted, “There has to be a more efficient way.” Participant 9 did use the filter option when completing Task 5, but then spent 45 seconds scrolling all workouts to complete the task. These usability issues caused significant confusion among our participants when looking for specific workouts, which harms the overall appeal of the app as a platform for people who rely on guided workouts as a method of discovering their fitness wants and needs.

### Recommendation: Relocate Search, Filter, and Sort buttons

Based on this finding, we recommend that Apple Fitness+ relocates these three key features. For the search feature, we recommend that Apple Fitness+’s search icon is placed permanently at the left side of the navigation bar. This would mitigate the confusion that occurs when users are unable to locate a search feature, especially due

to the significant amount of content on the app. This change would also align the Apple Fitness+ interface with Apple's other app interfaces, as shown in Figure 4, which greatly improves the usability of Apple Fitness+ for first-time users who are already familiar with Apple's UI system.

For the filter and sort features, we recommend that the buttons are redesigned to a uniform style and placed together on the page, eliminating the current mismatch between features that should be the same level of hierarchy. For the button design, we recommend the buttons resemble the current filter button. This would make both buttons filled neon green, and when placed next to each other, would greatly improve their visibility on the page.

## Key Finding & Recommendation #4:

### Finding: The Summary page does not clearly support goal-setting and workout planning

Several participants struggled to understand how Apple Fitness+ can support longer-term workout planning and goal-setting. While users could eventually complete individual workout discovery tasks, they had a harder time understanding how those workouts could be connected to a broader routine. This issue appeared in tasks related to setting goals, saving workouts for later, and planning future activity. Instead of feeling like a central home base for workout progress and planning, the summary page felt disconnected and thrown-together.

If users cannot easily connect Apple Fitness+ to their weekly goals, planned workout schedules, or preferred fitness routines, then the app becomes less useful as a long-term tool. Participants wanted the app to help them find not only what workout to do now, but also which workouts will fit into their broader progress.

Finding the goal setting options was difficult for multiple participants. Both Participant 1 and Participant 3 suggest that goals should be more visible on the summary page, either as a dedicated card or a separate block. Even accounting for Task 1 being the first time the participant had used Apple Fitness+, Participant 1 took 4:34 on Task 1 and eventually gave up. They were mainly using the custom plan feature to try to find how to adjust their calorie goals but, they navigated through the summary page multiple times and still weren't able to find goal setting options. Participant 1 said they expected goals to be found on the main screen: "I would've thought that goals would've been a tab that was involved on this [summary screen] and not through the profile" [where they eventually found the goal setting options]. Participant 8 was unable to locate the goal-setting feature through the "Summary" page, and instead used the user profile page to eventually locate the feature. Even with their previous experience with Apple's activity rings and movement goals (which Participant 2 noted helped them complete the task), they noted Task 1 as the most difficult task of the test. Users without any background knowledge of activity rings like Participant 3 tended to struggle more with this task.

Participant 11 wished that setting a workout schedule was easier, and felt that the app should prompt users with questions to determine what information is shown

and which workouts should be recommended. Participant 12 also wanted a calendar-style planning feature that would allow users to add workout videos, goals, and workout types to specific days.

Participants also raised concerns about the type of progress that is emphasized on the app. Participant 11 said that the app felt “old-school” in its approach to working out because of its focus on calories, while the participant felt that the current workout culture is moving towards overall health, specific muscle groups, nutrition, consistency, and wellbeing. This suggests that Apple Fitness+ may be missing the opportunity to support a broader range of user goals, beyond just calorie-burning and steps.

The severity of this issue is moderate to high, because unlike confusing navigation or buttons, this problem affects how users view and und the overall value of Apple Fitness+. A paid guided workout platform needs to help its users to build routines, stay motivated, and see progress over time. Without this, users may rely on competitors for these tools, reducing the likelihood that they continue their subscription.

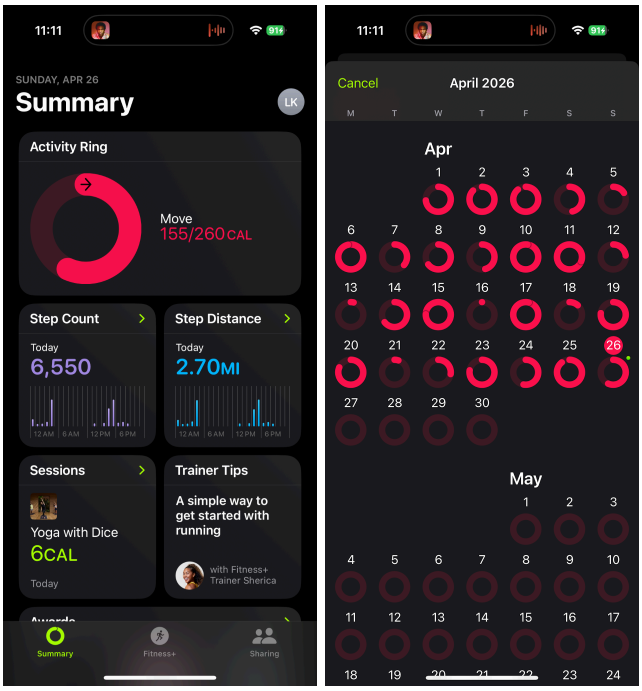



*Figure 5: The summary page that shows the only tracked activities being calories, steps, and distance, and the calendar view with only previous activity*

**Recommendation: Redesign the Summary Page around Goals, Planning, and Personalized Progress**

We recommend that Apple Fitness+ redesigns their summary page so it more clearly functions as a planning and progress hub. Currently, the summary page only shows previous activity. We want it to not only show this, but also help users understand what they are working towards and what they should do next.

First, Apple Fitness+ should add a dedicated **Goals** card near the top of the summary page. This card should show current weekly goals, progress towards these goals, and a clear call-to-action button that allows the user to adjust these goals. Instead of making users search through the app to manage goals and plans, this would centralize the goal-setting location in one that naturally matches user expectations.

Second, Apple Fitness+ should add a **Weekly Planning Calendar** block. This feature should allow users to assign workouts, workout types, saved programs, or custom goals to specific days. For example, a user could schedule strength training on Monday, a yoga session with Gregg Cook on Wednesday, and a cycling goal of 4 miles on Friday. This would fulfil some of our participant's desire for easier workout scheduling and would make Apple Fitness+ more useful for users trying to build and stick to a consistent routine.

Third, Apple Fitness+ should broaden its stats and tracking beyond just calorie and distance based targets. Users should be able to set goals relating to weight strength, consistency/time, mobility, and recovery. For example, users could set a goal to complete strength workouts per week and attach a weight goal to this timeline, or include a warm-up/cool-down stretch to their sessions. This would better reflect the current state of the fitness community's goals, making the app feel more personalized and current.

## Conclusion

Our usability test of Apple Fitness+ revealed key areas for Apple to improve the platform and strengthen Apple Fitness+'s position as a competitive platform in the guided workout market. Overall, most participants were able to complete tasks, although navigation issues were a very common barrier that led to significant time spent on task completion, or participants terminating/failing the tasks. This was significant because we focused our tasks on key areas of Apple Fitness+'s usability: searching for and discovering workout classes and plans, saving them for later, and customizing their playback experience in the Apple Fitness+ app. By focusing on

improved app navigation, labeling, and support of user goals, Apple can greatly reduce frustrations that our test data revealed and create a more cohesive and supportive experience.